Opting Out of Installation



If you don't want to install anything on your computer for some reason, you can take advantage of cloud-based development environments such as Replit or GitHub Codespaces. These environments enable you to write your code in a browser and run it against a cloud-based virtual machine.

Installing Ruby with the rbenv Version Manager

In order to facilitate our installation of Ruby, we are going to use a *version manager*, which is a tool that allows you to install and switch between multiple Ruby versions on the same machine. There are many reasons to use a version manager to handle your Ruby installation. Being able to easily switch between multiple versions of Ruby gives you the flexibility to work with multiple projects that might have been written at different times. In addition, the version managers have been created for easy installation, so installing multiple Ruby versions with a version manager is easier than installing a single version by itself. More powerful and easier to use is a hard combination to beat. If you are interested in just downloading one version of Ruby, you can find system-by-system instructions at https://www.ruby-lang.org/en/documentation/installation.

The tool we are going to use in this book is called rbenv.[4] Rbenv is not the only Ruby version manager, but it's probably the most commonly used these days. Other commonly used version managers are RVM[5] and chruby.[6] (And yes, having competing tools named "RVM" and "rbenv" is confusing.) If you are using version management for multiple languages, you might want to look at a project called asdf, which unifies different languages' version managers,[7] and is rapidly becoming more popular within Ruby.

We will install rbenv through the conveniently provided rbenv-installer program. If executing somebody else's shell script makes you nervous, you can inspect the script at https://github.com/rbenv/rbenv-installer/blob/main/bin/rbenv-installer before you run it.

From a command terminal, enter this command all on one line (the line is split here for page-width reasons):

```
$ curl -fsSL
  https://github.com/rbenv/rbenv-installer/raw/HEAD/bin/rbenv-installer | bash
```

Curl is a command-line tool for accessing URLs and doing something useful with the return value—in this case, retrieving a shell script from the rbenv GitHub repo and passing it along to a bash shell to be executed.

This script will install rbenv using the appropriate package manager for your system, and will also install a helper program called ruby-build that will manage the download and installation of different Ruby versions.

The installation command might produce a lot of output—especially if you are on a macOS system that uses the Homebrew package manager. On a Mac, it should end with the following, a Windows user under WSL might see something different:

4. https://github.com/rbenv/rbenv
5. https://rvm.io
6. https://github.com/postmodern/chruby
7. https://asdf-vm.com